

Staying Active with Arthritis in Winter: UK Guide to Cold-We

How to stay active with arthritis during UK winters. Indoor exercise ideas, layering tips, warm-up routines and motivation strategies for cold weather joint pain.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-14 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk



*Couple walking together in a UK autumn park, staying active with arthritis during cold weather
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Winter in the UK presents a particular challenge for the millions of people living with arthritis. Shorter days, cold temperatures, icy conditions and the natural inclination to

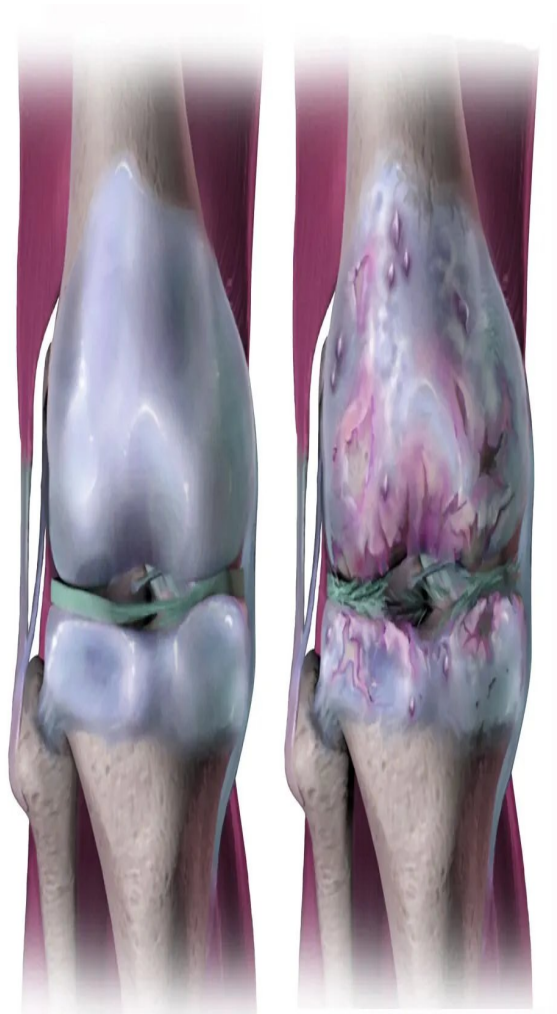
hibernate on the sofa can cause physical activity levels to plummet — yet staying active during winter is arguably **more important** than at any other time of year. Regular movement keeps joints lubricated, muscles strong, weight in check and mood elevated. This guide provides practical strategies for maintaining an active lifestyle throughout the British winter.

Why Winter Activity Matters More

The temptation to rest during cold weather is understandable, but inactivity creates a vicious cycle: less movement leads to stiffer joints, weaker muscles, weight gain and lower mood — all of which worsen arthritis symptoms. Research shows that physical activity levels in the UK drop by **20–30% during winter months**, and this decline is even more pronounced among people with chronic pain conditions.

Conversely, maintaining activity through winter helps keep synovial fluid flowing (the joint's natural lubricant), prevent deconditioning and muscle loss, support mental health (combating seasonal affective disorder), maintain a healthy weight through the calorie-dense festive season, and reduce the severity and duration of morning stiffness.

Indoor Exercise Options



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When outdoor conditions are poor, having indoor alternatives is essential.

Swimming and Aquatic Exercise

Indoor heated pools offer one of the best exercise environments for arthritis in winter. Warm water (typically 28–32°C) soothes joints, provides buoyancy that reduces weight-bearing stress by up to 90%, and allows movement that would be painful on land. Most UK leisure centres have heated indoor pools. Look for "aquafit" or "gentle aqua" classes specifically suited to people with joint conditions.

Home-Based Exercises

- Chair-based exercises — Full-body workout from the comfort of your living room. NHS and Arthritis UK have free YouTube videos
- Yoga and tai chi — Online classes allow you to practice in a warm home environment

- Resistance band exercises — Compact, affordable equipment for strength training at home
- Stationary cycling — Pedal exercisers (from £20) sit on the floor and can be used from a chair
- Stair exercises — If you have stairs, gentle step-ups using the bottom step provide excellent leg strengthening

Indoor Walking

- Shopping centres — many open early for "mall walking" groups
 - Indoor athletics tracks (some leisure centres have these)
 - Walking on the spot or marching in place while watching television
 - Indoor walking videos on YouTube (Leslie Sansone's "Walk at Home" series is popular)
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Exercising Outdoors Safely

If you prefer outdoor exercise, preparation is key:

Layering for Arthritis

- Base layer — Moisture-wicking thermal underwear keeps skin dry
- Middle layer — Fleece or wool for insulation
- Outer layer — Windproof and waterproof jacket
- Extremities — Thermal gloves (or arthritis compression gloves under warm gloves), warm hat, thermal socks. Heat loss through the head and hands significantly affects comfort
- Hand warmers — Reusable gel hand warmers (£2–£5) or disposable warmers can be placed in gloves or pockets

Safety on Ice and Wet Surfaces

- Wear shoes with good grip — look for deep treads and slip-resistant soles
- Use walking poles for stability on icy paths
- Walk on gritted surfaces where possible

- Take smaller steps to maintain balance
- Avoid walking after dark when ice is hard to see
- Slip-on ice grippers for shoes (£5–£15 from outdoor shops) provide extra traction

Warming Up in Cold Weather

Cold muscles and joints need a longer warm-up in winter. Spend 10–15 minutes warming up indoors before heading out: march on the spot, do gentle arm circles, knee lifts and ankle rolls. This increases blood flow to muscles and synovial fluid production before exposing joints to cold temperatures.

Motivation Strategies



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- Schedule exercise — Treat it as an appointment you can't cancel
 - Exercise buddy — Accountability makes you more likely to show up, especially on cold, dark days
 - Midday exercise — Take advantage of daylight during lunch breaks. Even 15 minutes of walking at lunchtime helps
 - Track your activity — Use a simple diary or step counter. Seeing progress is motivating
 - Set winter-specific goals — Rather than comparing to summer activity levels, set realistic winter targets
 - Reward yourself — Plan something enjoyable after exercise: a warm bath, hot chocolate, favourite TV programme
 - Remember the benefits — Exercise improves mood within minutes, and the effects last hours. On the coldest, darkest days, you'll feel the benefit most
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Vitamin D in Winter

Between October and March, the UK doesn't receive enough UVB sunlight for vitamin D production. Public Health England recommends all adults take a **10-microgram (400 IU) vitamin D supplement** daily during autumn and winter. Vitamin D is important for bone health, immune function and may help reduce arthritis-related inflammation.

Winter doesn't have to mean retreating from physical activity. With the right preparation, indoor alternatives and motivation strategies, you can stay active throughout the British winter and emerge in spring with stronger, more mobile joints. Our virtual assistant can help you create a winter exercise plan tailored to your abilities.

This article is for general information only. Consult your GP before starting a new exercise programme, particularly if you have balance problems or cardiovascular conditions.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about staying active with arthritis in winter: uk guide to cold-we?

Short answer: In winter, all adults in the UK should take a daily 10-microgram (400 IU) vitamin D supplement, as recommended by Public Health England. This is because between October and March, the UK does not receive enough sunlight for the body to produce sufficient vitamin D, which is vital for bone health, immune function, and may help reduce arthritis inflammation.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk